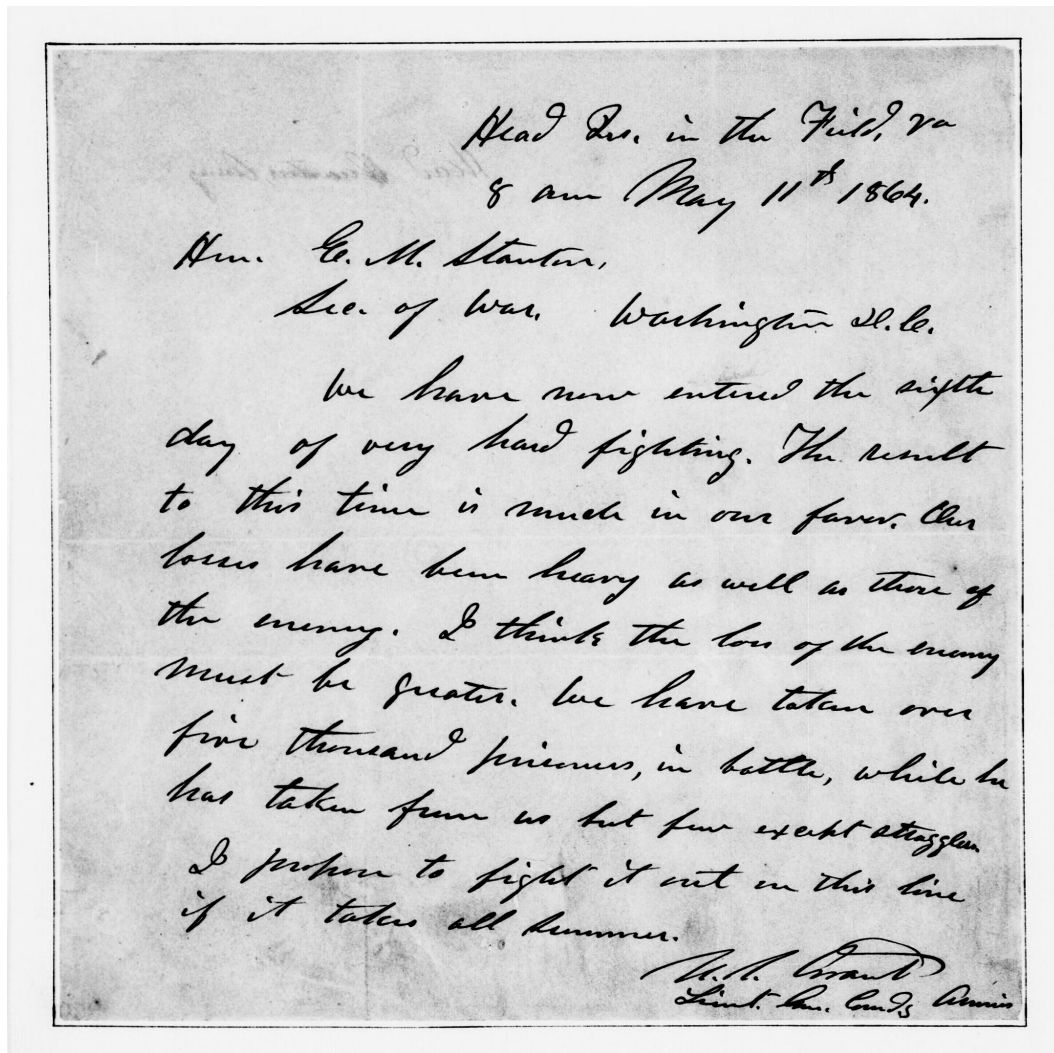


Grant to Stanton

Headquarters in the Field, Virginia • May 11, 1864, 8:00 A.M.



Original manuscript, Ulysses S. Grant Papers, Library of Congress. Grant sent a nearly identical dispatch to General Halleck within the same hour.

Transcription

Head Qrs. in the Field, Va.

8 A.M. May 11th, 1864.

Hon. E. M. Stanton,

Sec. of War, Washington, D.C.

We have now entered the sixth day of very hard fighting. The result to this time is much in our favor. Our losses have been heavy as well as those of the enemy. I think the loss of the enemy must be

greater. We have taken over five thousand prisoners, in battle, while he has taken from us but few except stragglers.

I propose to fight it out on this line if it takes all summer.

U. S. Grant

Lieut. Gen. Comdg. Armies

Note

Written near Spotsylvania Court House, five days after the Army of the Potomac's withdrawal from the Wilderness turned south rather than back across the Rapidan. Grant sent an essentially identical letter to Major General Henry Halleck, Chief of Staff, the same morning; the fuller Halleck version additionally reports Union losses at roughly eleven general officers and twenty thousand men, and requests reinforcements be routed to Belle Plain. Both dispatches were published within days and the “fight it out on this line” phrase became one of the most quoted lines of the war.